Dropfront GDD

Oct 20, 2026 · @kr0

Overview

This document defines how Dropfront plays: its loop, systems, cards and rules. The pitch, the build plan (TDD) and open questions each have their own tab. Values marked *proposed* are untested; the prototype uses them unless noted.

Design goals

- **Every turn is a trade.** Energy is short. Squads, tactics, gear and drop-ins all compete for it.
- **Short bursts, big stakes.** A drop-in lasts 20 seconds and can flip the match.
- **Gear for the situation.** Play gear cards to equip your hero, up to 2 at a time. Discard one to make room for what the next fight needs.
- **A match lasts 5 to 8 minutes.** Long enough to cycle the deck several times, short enough for one more. 8:00 is a hard cap.

Setting: a dieselpunk war. Rival armies fight over an industrial outpost with trench-era weapons, armored walkers and bombers.

Changelog

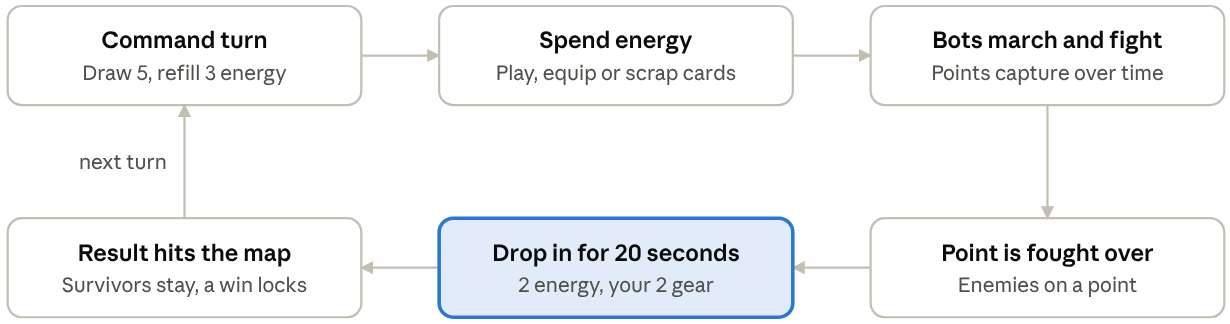
Date	Change	Why
Oct 20	Title Dropfront; dieselpunk setting; Orbital strike renamed Bomber run	Settled in the open questions review
Oct 20	Gear equips when played, 2 in play, discard to swap; no locker or pick screen	Gear works like normal cards in play
Oct 20	Map runs at 25% during drop-ins; regroup cut to 20s	Leaving the map should cost a little
Oct 20	Enemy commander plays a full mirror of your tactic cards	It should play the same game as you
Oct 20	Win at 2000 with an 8:00 real-time cap	Drop-ins pushed matches past 8 minutes

Date	Change	Why
Oct 20	Enemy squads are free on a timer; its energy pays for tactics and its champion	Its energy couldn't cover a squad every 5 seconds
Oct 20	Edge-case rules: ties, overflow enemies, player death, no gear	Gaps found in design review
Oct 20	Enemy champion can drop into fights	Make the enemy play the same game as you
Oct 20	Points renamed Watchtower, Quarry, Foundry, Refinery, Docks	Original names were borrowed
Oct 20	Pitch, TDD and open questions split into their own tabs	Keep the GDD to rules

Core loop

A match runs in real time for 5 to 8 minutes, with a command turn every 15 seconds of map time.

Plan every 15 seconds, then drop in to win the fight that matters



Each held point scores 2 per second. First to 2000 wins; at 8:00 the higher score wins.

core loop · 6 steps

1. **Command turn.** Discard what's left in your hand, draw 5 and refill to 3 energy. Unspent energy is lost.
2. **Spend.** Play squads and tactics on points, equip gear on your hero, or scrap cards for +1 energy each.

3. **Map runs.** Bots walk the roads, fight at points and move capture meters. The enemy commander sends squads, plays tactics and drops its champion into fights.
4. **Drop in.** Any point with enemies on it can be dropped into for 2 energy. You fight for 20 seconds with your equipped gear while the map runs at 25% speed. Your hero then regroups for 20 seconds.
5. **Resolve.** Survivors go back to the point. Clear every enemy and the point is yours and locked for 10 seconds.

Systems

Winning

- Each owned point scores **2 resources per second** of map time. The first side to **2000** wins.
- **Time limit:** at **8:00** of real time (drop-ins included), the higher score wins.
- **Ties:** if both sides pass 2000 on the same tick, or the scores are equal at 8:00, whoever holds more points wins. If that is also tied, the next point to change owner decides it.
- **Expected length (proposed, to be checked by the headless runner):**

Points held by the leader	Map time to 2000	Real time with about 6 drop-ins
5	3:20	4:50
4	4:10	5:40
3	5:33	7:03
2 or fewer	Over 8:00	Time limit decides

Map and capture

- One map with five points: **Watchtower**, **Quarry**, **Foundry** (center), **Refinery** and **Docks**. Eight roads connect them, and each side has a home base off the map's edge.
- Each point has a capture meter from -100 (enemy) to +100 (you). One side alone on a point moves the meter at 10 plus 3 per bot each second. With both sides there, it moves 2 per second for each bot of difference, toward the bigger side.
- At +100 or -100 the point is owned. It turns neutral when the meter crosses 0.
- **Locked** means the meter can't move. Bots still fight there.

Bots and combat

- Squads spawn at home and walk to their target at 55 units per second (heavies walk at 42). The map is 800 by 500 units.
- When both sides are on a point, each side builds up losses at 0.11 per enemy bot per second. A bot dies each time a side's total reaches 1.0.
- Heavies deal double losses while defending a point you own. They die after your rifle bots at that point.
- You never control bots directly. Cards are the only way to steer them.

Energy and drop-in limits

- You get 3 energy each turn. Unspent energy is lost. Overclock (+2) and 2 scraps can raise one turn to **7 at most**.
- During a drop-in the map runs at **25% speed**, so the battle keeps moving while you fight.
- After a drop-in your hero **regroups for 20 seconds** of map time (40 if you went down).

Enemy commander

- **Squads are free.** Every 4 to 6 seconds it sends 2 to 3 bots. It scores each point: defend owned points under attack, take neutral ones, hit your weak ones, prefer what's close. A little randomness keeps it from being predictable. Feint makes it chase the point you choose for 8 seconds.
- **Energy.** It gains 3 energy per turn (cap 6) and spends it on tactics and champion drop-ins.
- **Tactics.** It plays a full mirror of your tactic cards (Feint, Rally, Hold the line, Flare, Sabotage, Overclock) from its own deck. Each one shows on the map for 2 seconds so you can read it.
- **Champion drop-in** (2 energy). It drops its champion into a point it owns with 3 or more of your bots on it, or a point it's attacking whose meter is at neutral or better for it. Earliest drop: 0:45.
- **On the map,** the champion counts as 4 bots at that point for 20 seconds and can't be killed there.
- **If you drop into that point,** you fight the champion: 15 HP, faster than bots, and 2 gear the commander picks at the start of the match.

- **Ramp-up.** After 3:00 of map time its squads get one bot bigger. After 5:00 it sends a second squad with each decision.

Champion edge cases

- Beaten means its HP reaches 0. It then can't drop in again for 30 seconds.
- If it survives your drop-in, it stays on the map until its 20 seconds run out, then rests for 10.
- Its 20-second timer runs on map time, so it slows to 25% during your drop-ins.
- Only one champion is on the map at a time, and it can't drop into the point you're fighting at.

Drop-in firefight

- **Gear:** you fight with whatever gear is equipped (0 to 2 pieces). There is no pick screen.
- **Arena:** top-down, four cover walls, and a capture circle in the middle. It lasts 20 seconds while the map runs at 25%.
- **Base rifle:** 1 damage, about 6 shots per second, range about 500 units. Bots have 3 HP and you have 10.
- **Who fights:** up to 6 of your bots and 8 enemies from that point, plus the champion if it's there. Bots that arrive at the point during the fight wait outside.
- **The fight ends** when time runs out, when every enemy in the arena is down, or when you go down.

Outcomes

Result	Effect on the point
Every enemy down, none left outside the arena	Yours, locked for 10 seconds
Every enemy down, some left outside (over 8)	Meter moves 50 your way; the rest stay
Time runs out, you're on the capture circle	Meter moves 25 your way
Time runs out elsewhere	No change; survivors go back
You go down	Survivors go back; 40-second regroup

Cards

There are three card types. Squads put bots on the map, tactics bend the battle, and gear unlocks tools for your hero.

Gear: equip, discard to swap

- Playing a gear card **equips** it on your hero. It stays in play, out of your hand and deck, until you discard it.
- Up to **2** gear can be in play. With 2 equipped, discard one before playing another.
- **Discarding** equipped gear is free and can be done any time on the command map, never during a drop-in. It goes to your discard pile and comes back when the deck reshuffles.
- Both equipped gear are active in every drop-in.
- Equipping gear thins your deck, so squads and tactics come up more often.
- Between matches, all gear returns to your deck.

Scrap for energy

- Scrap any card in your hand for **+1 energy**, up to **2 scraps per turn**. Scrapped cards go to the discard pile.
- Scrapping turns a dead hand into a drop-in. Two scraps take you to 5 energy, enough for a drop-in and a Reinforcement wave in the same turn.

Starter deck (17 cards)

Card	Cost	Type	Effect	Target
Rifle squad (x3)	1	Squad	Send 3 bots	Any point
Rushers	1	Squad	2 bots appear instantly	A point connected by road to one you hold
Heavy squad	2	Squad	Send 2 heavies; they deal double losses while defending	Any point
Sniper nest	2	Squad	+1 bot; kills 1 enemy bot every 1.5s on squads within 140 units	A point you hold

Card	Cost	Type	Effect	Target
Reinforcement wave	3	Squad	6 bots appear instantly	A point you hold
Feint	0	Tactic	Enemy commander chases this point for 8s	Any point
Rally	1	Tactic	Your bots on connected points march here	Any point
Hold the line	1	Tactic	Freeze the capture meter for 10s	A fought-over point
Flare	1	Tactic	Draw 2	None
Sabotage	2	Tactic	Point stops scoring for 20s	An enemy point
Overclock	1	Tactic	+2 energy next turn; exhausts	None
Shotgun	2	Gear	Your gun fires a 5-pellet close-range blast	Equip
Jump pack	1	Gear	3 dashes per drop-in; kills recharge one	Equip
Medic drone	1	Gear	Heal 1.2 HP per second while on the capture circle	Equip
Bomber run	3	Gear	Once per drop-in: mark an area that is bombed 2s later	Equip

Exhausts means the card leaves your deck for the rest of the match.

Run structure and controls

Run

- A run is 3 matches, at most 24 minutes. Lose a match and the run ends.
- After each win, draft 1 of 3 cards from a pool of **20** (proposed) into your deck.
- The champion's gear comes from the same 4 gear you can unlock.

- **Per-match ramp (proposed):** match 2 squad timer -0.5s and +1 bot per squad; match 3 the same again, and the champion gets 20 HP.

Controls

Action	Mouse and keyboard	Touch
Play a card	Click the card, then a highlighted point. Number keys 1 to 9 pick cards in hand order	Tap the card, then the point
Equip gear	Click a gear card (with 2 equipped, discard one first)	Same with taps
Discard equipped gear	Click the gear in your loadout bar, then confirm	Same with taps
Scrap a card	Right-click the card, or hover it and press X	Long-press the card
Drop in	Click a point marked Drop in	Tap the point
Move, aim, shoot	WASD, mouse, hold left click	Hold where you want to go; you fire automatically
Dash (Jump pack)	Space	Double-tap
Bomber run	Q, then click the target	Tap its loadout slot, then the target
Cancel or pause	Esc or the Pause button	The Pause button

Art, audio and UI

- **Look:** a dark war table with a dieselpunk feel: riveted steel, oil stains, stencil type. Flat shapes, blue for you, red for the AI, amber for anything you can act on (drop-in prompts, energy, contested points). There are no character sprites on the map, only dots and rings.
- **Drop-ins:** the same flat style, zoomed in. You're a pointed blue arrow, bots are discs with HP bars, and walls are solid blocks. Hit-stop and screen shake carry the punch.
- **Type:** a condensed display face for names and numbers, and a plain sans for card text.

- **UI:** the score race and turn timer at the top, the map in the middle, then the loadout bar and hand at the bottom. A card's valid targets light up as soon as you hover it.
- **Audio:** a ticking clock in the last 3 seconds of a turn, distinct chimes for a capture and a loss, and a short drum hit on drop-in. No music in the first release.

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Champion	The enemy commander's hero. Drops into fights like you do
Drop in	Fight personally at a point for 20 seconds
Equipped	A gear card in play on your hero, up to 2
Exhaust	The card leaves your deck for the rest of the match
Locked	A point whose meter can't move for 10 seconds
Map time	Match time that runs at full speed on the map and 25% during drop-ins
Regroup	Your hero's 20-second wait between drop-ins
Scrap	Discard a card from hand for +1 energy, 2 per turn